

The California Native & Drought-Tolerant Plant Cheat Sheet

Right plant, right place. Once it is established, a California native will thrive on very little summer water. The trick is choosing for your exact spot and planting at the right time of year.

Which native for your spot?

- **Sunny dry slope:** California poppy, California buckwheat, and manzanita want heat, lean soil, and sharp drainage.
- **Pollinator or butterfly garden:** ceanothus, hummingbird sage, and buckwheat feed bees and butterflies for months.
- **Shade under oaks:** hummingbird sage and toyon tolerate dry shade. Keep this zone unwatered to protect the oak.
- **Hedge, screen, or small tree:** toyon and the taller ceanothus form a dense evergreen screen.

At a glance

Plant	Type	Sun	Water
California poppy	Annual, reseeding	Full sun	Very low
Ceanothus (CA lilac)	Shrub	Full sun	Very low
Manzanita	Shrub	Full sun, part shade	Very low
Toyon	Large shrub, small tree	Full sun, part shade	Low
Buckwheat or sage	Groundcover, perennial	Full sun, part shade	Low

Water needs are for established plants. Every native needs regular water through its first year to settle in.

Planting

- Plant in fall so the winter rains settle the roots before summer heat arrives.
- Do not amend or fertilize most natives. Rich soil and compost push weak, short-lived growth.
- Mulch with leaf litter or coarse bark, and keep the mulch pulled back off the crown so it does not rot.

Watering

- Water regularly to establish through the first year, then taper off each season.
- The number-one native killer is summer water on established plants, especially manzanita and ceanothus, which rot when the soil stays wet in the heat.

Central Coast notes

- Choose species locally native to your area, not just California native in general.
- Avoid rich soil, compost, and fertilizer. Natives evolved for our lean coastal ground.
- Deer-resistance varies by plant and by herd, so protect young plants until established.
- Check Calscape (calscape.org) for the exact species suited to your zip code and conditions.

Top three beginner mistakes

1. Overwatering established natives in summer, the fastest way to kill manzanita and ceanothus.
2. Amending or fertilizing the soil, which gives lush growth now and weak plants later.
3. Planting in spring instead of fall, so the roots miss the free winter rains.

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